

COMPETITOR RESEARCH SYSTEM

Micro-SaaS Moat Blueprint

The Prompt Pack — offline copy of all six modules.

Every prompt in this pack works on the free tier of Perplexity, ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini. Paid tiers mean deeper research per prompt, not different prompts.

Work the modules in order — each one takes the previous module's output as input. Replace anything in [square brackets] with your own details before sending.

One habit worth building: ask the AI to cite its sources, then spot-check two of them. Review sites frequently rank their own product first, and a competitor map built on one biased listicle is worse than no map at all.

MODULE 1

Competitor Discovery

Find everyone already serving this niche — not just the two or three names you already know. Aim for 8 to 15 before moving on. Fewer than eight usually means the search wasn't broad enough, not that the niche is empty.

I'm evaluating a micro-SaaS idea: [describe your idea in 1-2 sentences].

Find every existing product that competes for the same buyer's budget -- direct competitors (same solution), indirect competitors (different solution, same problem), and adjacent tools users currently duct-tape together instead. Include small/indie tools, not just market leaders.

For each one give: name, one-line description, pricing model, and how you found it (search term, directory, forum mention).

Record where each name came from. If they all came from one listicle, you have one source's opinion, not a market map.

MODULE 2

Competitor Teardown

Go deep on the three to five competitors that actually matter — closest positioning, most traction, or most similar pricing. Run this prompt once per competitor.

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Research [competitor name] in depth. I need:  
1. Their exact pricing tiers and what's gated behind each  
2. Their core feature list, grouped by category  
3. Who their marketing/positioning is clearly built for  
4. Any recent product or pricing changes in the last 6 months  
5. Public complaints -- search their name plus "alternative", "vs",  
   "sucks", or check G2/Reddit/Trustpilot for recurring frustrations
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Cite where each finding comes from.
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Complaints are the highest-value field here. A recurring complaint across multiple sources is a gap someone will pay to have solved.

MODULE 3

Feature Parity Matrix

Put every feature that surfaced in Module 2 into one table — including features you don't plan to build. The empty cells are the point.

Here are teardowns of [N] competitors: [paste your Module 2 notes].

Build a feature comparison matrix. Rows = every distinct feature that appeared across any competitor. Columns = each competitor, plus a column for my planned product.

Mark each cell: has it / partial / doesn't have it. Group related features together. Flag any feature that ONLY one competitor has.

Build this by hand if the AI output is messy — the value is in you seeing the gaps, not in the table being pretty.

MODULE 4

Gap and Wedge Finder

Turn the matrix into an actual opportunity. Not every empty cell is a gap worth filling — this step separates the three kinds.

Here is a feature comparison matrix for [niche] tools:
[paste your Module 3 table].

Identify:

1. Gaps unserved because building them is hard
(real moat if I solve it)
2. Gaps unserved because nobody asked yet
(validate before building)
3. Gaps unserved because they're genuinely low-value
(skip these)

For each real gap, name the specific buyer segment who'd care most.

If the AI can't explain WHY a gap is unserved, treat it as category 3 until proven otherwise. Big companies usually aren't stupid — they've usually decided it isn't worth it.

MODULE 5

Moat Scoring

Score the gap before you build it. A gap you can fill in a weekend is a gap a competitor can close in a weekend too.

Based on this gap analysis: [paste Module 4 output]

Score my planned wedge on each of these five factors, 1-5, with a one-line justification for each score:

1. Data moat -- does it get better with more usage/user data?
2. Network effects -- more valuable as more people use it?
3. Switching cost -- painful for users to leave once adopted?
4. Distribution advantage -- do I already reach this buyer?
5. Technical complexity -- genuinely hard to clone quickly?

Be harsh. Justify low scores rather than inflating them.

Reading the score — under 10: this is a feature, not a company. 10 to 17: viable niche, expect competition in 6 to 12 months. 18+: defensibility compounds, worth the build time.

MODULE 6

Validated Roadmap

Convert everything above into something you can act on this week.

Based on this research: [paste your Modules 1-5 summary]

Write a prioritized v1 feature roadmap. For each feature give:

- A one-sentence user story
- Why it's prioritized there (tie back to the gap/moat analysis)
- Rough build effort: small / medium / large

Then write a 3-sentence positioning statement for a landing page, based on the actual gap found -- not generic startup language.

Before you close the template: prioritized list (ordered, not a wish list), one positioning statement, moat score recorded, and a named buyer segment.

WHEN YOU'RE DONE

Reading your own result

A good run of this process does not end in a green light. It ends in a score, a named risk, and a specific next action. If your moat score came out at 20+ on the first pass, re-read your justifications — scoring your own idea generously is the most common way this process fails.

A 13 out of 25 with a clear wedge and a known weakness is a more useful result than a 22 you talked yourself into.

Want this run for you instead of by you? The done-for-you version of this exact process is available as a service — see the link on your Gumroad receipt.